



Thought Leadership presentation by Dr Alok Nath De

remained headstrong and mastered the language pretty soon.

At an institute of IIT's stature—where the brightest minds of the country came to make their dreams come true—Alok Nath found there were many who were just as meritorious as him. But he took it as a blessing in disguise, as he was always looking for a more competitive space where his limits could be tested, and his mind could expand.

Alok Nath says, "It's important to accept that some people are better than you at something and it's absolutely okay to be not as good as them. But what is important is to bring yourself to a minimum threshold level on attributes that matter in life and excel in a few dimensions."

As his world-view expanded and he met more people, Alok Nath found his calling—telecommunications—at IIT Kharagpur a fascinating field indeed! "I saw the power of communications and how it helped people stay connected remotely. I saw how it could compete with transportation and thought it was revolutionary."

The realisation didn't occur overnight, though. He spent months and months reading books and magazines, listening to radio, and talking to people to soak in as much information as possible and then come to this conclusion. "Inquisitiveness

to explore makes a big difference. When you keep your queries alive, one fine morning you'll come across some information that makes you pause. And you take a moment to think about it and ask further questions. It is in this process of asking and answering these questions that you realise what you are drawn to."

A three-step process Alok Nath likes to follow for his goal is ABC of Achievement: Align (your thoughts), Beam (your energy), and Collaborate (your ecosystem). As he began the seeding for his future roles, he realised how telecommunication systems could be built with hardware and then-new software elements. He also started appreciating how engineering deployment could complement technological innovations.

Dream job and memories at IISc

The unpredictability of life is enthralling. It makes you do things you never intended to, and gives you results you never expected. Although Alok Nath had planned to pursue his master's degree after IIT and even got admission to a US university, a financial crisis forced him to start working right after his graduation in 1985. Yet, he did not let this setback derail him from his plans.

Thankfully for Alok Nath, he

found his way to Bharat Electronics Ltd (BEL). In an era when MNCs did not rule the subcontinent, PSUs were the dream job of many, and Alok Nath was no different.

But, while joining BEL, he knew what his ultimate goal was—to learn telecommunication systems as much as he could.

At BEL, he was part of a team that built a low-flying target detection radar, which was the first indigenously built radar system: INDRA 1. Till date, INDRA series of radars are deployed on the borders of India.

His role in BEL, Sahibabad needed him to travel a lot to the headquarters in Bangalore (now Bengaluru). He made it a rule to take a different route during each of his trips. This was his way of having fun and exploring the country while working. As he travelled the length and breadth of India, Alok Nath's mantra to always go out of his comfort zone found more strength. "Even today, whenever I see that I'm getting too comfortable, I try to find new things to do that make me uncomfortable for a while."

But going out of your comfort zone can be scary besides being uncomfortable. How did he tackle that? He says, "The trick is to keep yourself anchored 50% in comfort and unsettle the rest. Going completely out of your comfort zone makes it probably very risky. Bring stability from the comfort zone, and growth from outside the comfort zone."

After a two-year stint at BEL, Alok Nath went on to pursue his master's degree from another premier institute of India—IISc Bangalore. A fond memory of IISc that he holds close to his heart, beyond studies, is how he would save some money from his scholarship grant to buy cassettes of classical music. An avid lover of classical music since a young age, Alok Nath had even tried learning the stringed musical instrument sitar. Although he could not sing well, his affinity for classical music drove him